

"EdCIL envisages to diversify its business in new scenarios post covid"

In Conversation with **Mr. Manoj Kumar**, Chairman & Managing Director, Educational Consultants India Limited (EdCIL-India)

What is the overall mandate of the EdCIL and how far has the company been able to successfully accomplish it?

Ans: EdCIL has the privilege of being the only Central Public Sector Enterprise (Mini Ratna Category-I) under the Ministry of Education and is mandated to provide project management and consultancy services in one of the priority development areas of the Government of India, i.e., the education sector. EdCIL started out as an Advisory/consultancy company and till date the vertical remains one of its flagship divisions. We are proud to state that EdCIL has prepared Detailed Project Reports for setting up of many prestigious institutions in the country and abroad in diversified fields. EdCIL is also focused to provide services in all emerging areas of IT/ICT in the education space.

Based on a strategic road-map, EdCIL has continued its growth path in the last 5 years and aims to position itself as one of the best-in-class educational project management firms in the country.

How much do you think IT/ICT interventions have changed the education scenario in India? How much has EdCIL contributed towards realisation of this goal?

Ans: While India has made significant progress in the education sector, major issues have to be addressed through implementation partners. With growing internet and smart-phone penetration in India, it is evident that IT/ICT can act as a game-changer for the sector. In view of this advancement of ed-tech, EdCIL also offers customised and scalable IT/ICT solution in the education sector that can address the issues related to access, quality, equity and governance.

What are the achievements of GoI's important scheme "Study in India" being implemented by EdCIL to increase the number of inbound foreign students to study at globally recognized premier institutions across India?

Ans: The Study in India (SII) programme aims to brand India as a popular education destination and increase inflow of international students.

The programme involves partnership with top Indian institutes/universities and focuses on countries across South-East Asia, Middle East and Africa. The bedrock of the programme is a web-portal (www.studyinindia.gov.in) which enables international students to apply for any course in any of the selected Indian institutions.

The programme has gained popularity across the globe with web-search for 'study in India' emerging from nearly all across the globe. Further, the partner institutes have been able to increase the number of incoming students through the programme multi-fold in just 3 academic years. We are positive that the gaining popularity of the programme will be able to present India as an international education destination.

Can you throw light about the recent educational projects conducted by EdCIL abroad?

Ans: One of the major projects undertaken by EdCIL recently is the Early Digital Learning Programme (EDLP). It is a flagship project of the Ministry of Education and Human Resources (MOEHR), Republic of Mauritius and aims at qualitatively transforming the teaching and learning environment through use of ed-tech in primary education of Mauritius.

Through this project EdCIL has provided an end-to-end solution covering tablets, ICT instruments with digital interactive content. Classroom Management system has also been provided to enable a personalised learning environment.

Based on the success of the project, the Mauritius government is contemplating to extend this to Grade V students.

What were the challenges faced by EdCIL during the disruption in education caused by the Covid-19 pandemic?

Ans: Covid-19 has had a disruptive effect on all the sectors and business. EdCIL, like other organisations, also faced multiple challenges due to the sudden onset of the pandemic. The business for the first 2 quarters of FY 2020-21 and FY 2021-22 also got impacted for EdCIL. However, the business strategy was revised to meet the goals of the year.

The Online Testing and Assessment division implemented various Covid protocols to conduct the examinations safely. Similarly, for the second major vertical, i.e., Digital Education Services, the team utilised the lockdown period to come up with new product strategies and empanelled new service partners. The division was able to provide various new solutions during the Covid-19 period.

These strategic interventions ensured that EdCIL continued the growth journey in spite of the business for initial 2 quarters being affected by Covid-19.

What is the way ahead for EdCIL in the post-Covid era?

After reassessing the future plan as well as finding new business opportunities in the post Covid era, EdCIL envisages to grow its business by at least two-fold in next three years by diversifying both geographically and by introducing new solutions in the education sector.